ANAGUTA PEOPLE, A BRIEF HISTORY

INTRODUCTION

The name 'Anaguta' is derived from two **Iguta** words: "**Ana**" meaning "Owner" while "**Uta**" means "Bow". Therefore, the meaning of Anaguta is "***The Owners of the Bow***". The language of Anaguta people is called Iguta; which is spoken by all Anaguta with minor variations as a result of dialectical differences. The Anaguta people are subdivided into five (5) clans:

1. Anabor
2. Andoho (Zangam)
3. Anagohom
4. Andigwong, and
5. Andirghiza.

Each of these clans consists of several extended family units referred to as "Ashibi".

The advent of colonialism introduced different religious practices apart from the traditional religions, rites and worships that existed. Colonialism created a range of options in religious choice and practices amongst people. Today, the Anaguta people are adherents of different religious practices, prominent amongst which are: Christianity, African traditional religion, Islam, and Judaism, all bonded by Uguta blood.

A significant proportion of Anaguta land today has been overtaken by development, through physical structures that are a consequence of societal growth. This of course was made possible by Jos being capital of Plateau State. The topography that constituted Anaguta land included high Plateaus, hills and flat land, with beautiful undulations, rock formations, captivating sceneries and fertile land with potentials for agriculture, economic ventures and tourism development.

ORIGIN OF ANAGUTA PEOPLE

Like other preliterate societies and cultures, the origin of the Anaguta people is empirically disjointed and largely mixed up with myths and legends. The constant alteration in the narration of facts and history, being passed from one generation to another is one of the factors responsible for this regrettable state of affairs. There has been attempts by other people to give a somewhat false version of the origin of Anaguta people without success.

A people's history ought to be narrated by the natives themselves. Any order attempt by different sources will be contrary and certainly misleading.
Mythologically, the Anaguta people have one consistent tradition. The elders firmly believe that Anaguta emerged from a cave at a place called "Akotom" located near Shere Hills. This myth is consistent with various theories of the origin of Plateau people, which affirms that the Plateau has been preoccupied for a time beyond living memory. This assertion confirms the Anaguta people as one of the autochthonous ethnic groups on the Plateau.

GEOGRAPHICAL LOCATION OF ANAGUTA PEOPLE

Geographically, Anaguta are located on the hills of Jos Plateau in North Central Nigeria, West Africa.

In specific terms, the Anaguta people are found in Gwong District of the defunct Jos Local Government Area of Plateau State, which had an area of 1,695 sq km and the Anaguta land stretches to about 106 sq km.

Gwong District shares boundary with Toro Local Government Area of Bauchi State and Bassa Local Government in the northern part; in the south by Du District, in the west by the Rukuba and Irigwe people of Bassa LGA, and in the east by Shere District of Jos East Local Government Area of Plateau State. It lies between 9.9°N and 8.8°E. The district stands beautifully on the northern edge of the Plateau named after itself. Its height is about 1,200M above sea level.

LANGUAGE CATEGORIZATION

Linguists and historians have identified "Iguta" as spoken by the Anaguta people as its native language to belong to the Platoid languages in the Benue-Congo group of languages in linguistic classification. (William et al., 1968)

CLIMATE

On the basis of available climate data, the Anaguta people are located on the high plateau region with much more pleasant weather than that of the surrounding plains. The weather, like that of other parts of the defunct Jos Local Government, is cool almost all year round from May to February. As such, the people enjoy a mild climate which has made Jos city a holiday resort both nationally and internationally.

The Anaguta identified seasonal changes (weather) and clearly differentiated the weather into four overlapping cyclic seasons as: *Rishi,* (*Spring)*- between March and May, *Rukozo* (*Summer*)- between June and August, *Uswama*, (*Autumn or Fall*)- between September and November, and *Maini*, (*Winter*)- between December and February, respectively.

VEGETATION

Of the five major vegetational zones of the country, the Anaguta people are situated within the savannah region (Guinea Savannah). The vegetation consists mainly of grass except in some nearby villages where thick hedges of cactus have been planted around household farms and compounds. The main farmlands are completely devoid of trees and so are the flat topmost laterite hills. Fringing woodlands and bamboo thickets may still be found along the valley of the more isolated streams.

Generally, the vegetation of the Anaguta people can be described as that of a grassland with dotted trees mostly along valleys, streams, and mountain tops.

OCCUPATION

The historical trajectory of Anaguta has been fascinating. It is characterized by change and continuity in their socio-cultural, economic and political life especially when viewed from the pre-colonial, colonial and post-colonial era. Economically, Anaguta had practiced both hunting and agriculture since the pre-colonial era. Hunting was carried out using traps, Bows and Arrows. Hunting was classified and undertaken by an individual or as a communal endeavor. Individual hunting is carried out by singularly by individuals while the communal hunting is organised by the community. The chief hunter called ***"Udawa***" or "***Udauji***" organizes the communal hunting expedition with the approval of the Ujah. The use of Bows and arrows for hunting purposes steadily declined with the advent of locally fabricated guns by the colonial masters. Urbanization has also significantly affected the observance of hunting.

Agriculture as part of the pre-colonial economic venture of the Anaguta people was essentially based on subsistence farming, using crude implements by family members. Farming today in Anaguta land is a major integral part of the economy. Crops grown include Guinea corn as the main crop, along with millet, sorghum, maize, cocoyam, fonio (Acha), sweet potatoes, and finger millet (Tamba). At the turn of the century, vegetables such as tomatoes, cabbage, onions, pepper, carrots, Amaranthus (Aleho), and guava fruit are produced in large quantities during the rainy and dry seasons along the streams and ponds, for domestic and commercial use.

POLITICAL AND ADMINISTRATIVE STRUCTURE OF THE ANAGUTA PEOPLE.

The contemporary political structure of Anaguta people can be traced back to many decades. What is currently obtainable is the outcome of cumulative evolutionary processes. During the pre-colonial era, the ***Pozoh Gbwau*** doubled as the ***Ujah*** and Chief Priest of Anaguta, that is, both the Spiritual and Political leader of the nation. Pozoh Gbwau performed his spiritual duties alongside ***Pozoh Andoho, Pozoh Nagohom*** and others known as the *"Irebah."* His political functions were performed alongside: ***Tipozoh Tupana, Irebah, Adiganu, Amiza Nata, Izhang and Tilari***. The system was gerontocracy, in nature and practice. Jullian steward observed that "Anaguta's most significant authorities were sacred, non-political figures who were reluctant to deal with outsiders and decision making was local, democratic and decentralized." Nonetheless, colonial incursion has led to the separation of spiritual roles from political roles of Pozoh Gbwau/Ujah. Presently, Pozoh Gbwau (Pozoh Iguano Izhang) is different from Ujah; while Pozoh Gbwau (Pozoh Utupana shubi) remains the spiritual leader. Ujah is the administrative/political leader of Anaguta.

THE STOOL OF UJAH ANAGUTA, JOS

Prior to European invasion of Anagutaland in 1902 and the amalgamation of Nigeria in 1914, the traditional institution of Anaguta has been in existence under the leadership of the Priest Chief (Sarkin Tsafi) known as the Ujah. But the subtle entry of British colonial officials with their indirect rule policy in Northern Nigeria and the search for coherence/cheap administrative policy led to the creation of Districts. Sequel to colonial administrative policy, Anaguta (Naraguta) District, which later metamorphosed to Gwong

District with a land area of about 90.sq miles was created alongside other districts that makes up the then Jos division which included the following:

i. Achakka (Rukuba) **viii. Jere** **xv. Vom**

ii. Amo **ix. Kuru**

iii. Buji **x. Kwall (Irigwe)**

iv. Forom **xi. Machi**

v. Ganawuri **xii. Naraguta (Anaguta)**

vi. Gashit **xiii. Rim**

vii. Haifan **xiv. Ropp**

The gazetteer of Plateau province, Nigeria compiled by C.G. Ames (1932, p. 57) paragraphs 1 and 111 respectively buttresses the fact out of the fifteen Districts, the area occupied by Naraguta (Anaguta) District which is now Anaguta Chiefdom is made up of 90 square miles. In addition, the political map of Jos Division, No. M60 1927 indicates that Anaguta Chiefdom is bounded in the North-East by Toro LGA of Bauchi State and Shere and Fobur District of Jos East LGA in the East. In the South, Anaguta Chiefdom is bounded by Du and Gyel Districts and also shares boundaries with Pengana and Rukuba (Kiche) in the West. These fifteen Districts listed above eventually made up the present *Jos North, Bassa, Riyom, Barkin Ladi* and Jos South Local Government Areas, and they were independent of one another when Jos became the Divisional Headquarters in 1912. Furthermore, it was these Districts that became the Jos Native Authority (N.A.) for administrative purposes. The District were later divided into three Councils: Anaguta, Berom, Ganawuri and Irigwe were members of Riyom Council. The council Centre was called Gbong Dutshot. The Districts of Buji, Amo and Jere formed Pengana Council and Rukuba also became a Council. At the formation of Northern Nigeria Council of Chiefs with headquarters at Kaduna, the need for a representative from Jos Division became necessary. In 1947, Mallam Rwang Pam M.B.E, the Chief of Berom, was appointed the 1st Chief to represent Jos in the Council of Chiefs at Kaduna. Between 1968 and 1996, Rukuba, Irigwe, Pengana, Ganawuri and Jarawa were upgraded to Chiefdoms while Anaguta remained a District. Furthermore, the continuous existence of Naraguta District is well documented in colonial records. The Jos province report titled: Jos Prov. 2/1993 No. 64 on Jos division for the year ending 31st December 1932, by the District Officer (D.O) states that "the chief event of administrative interest and importance during the March Quarter by the Ujah (Sarkin Tsafi) of Naraguta District headship is that he and previous holders of the post have resolutely refused for some years past to take executive office through fear of religious inhabitation which were skillfully played by the ruling family." but after prolong negotiations; the Ujah accepted the District headship on the condition that he was not asked to perform judicial functions. To meet his wishes, his nominee Abamu was appointed the president of the Native Court. Thus, Naraguta was the only District in Jos Division where Executive functions are separated from

judicial functions. In terms of succession to the throne of Ujah, the Anaguta nation based on recorded history has had eight (8) kings who ruled and served as custodians of the Anaguta cultural heritage, value systems, norms and traditions of the people. These heroes all fought gallantly to preserve, maintain and sustain the cultural heritage of the Chiefdom in conformity with the lows of the land and without being antagonistic to constituted authorities. They are as follows:

1. Pozoh Bahal from 1926 to 1928;

2. Pozoh Akumusu from 1928 to 1929;

3. Pozoh Akum from 1930 to 1931;

4. Pozoh Magaji Kuludu from 1931 to 1932;

5. Pozoh Abamu Awang from 1932 to 1957;

6. Pozoh Azachi Yusuf Shiga from 1958 to 1971;

7. Pozoh Sauni S. Werr from 1974 to 1977;

8. Pozoh Jauro Magaji from 1978 to 2021

By the year, 2002 the stool of Ujah was upgraded from District to Chiefdom on Second Class status by the Chief Joshua Chibi Dariye led administration on the 31st March, 2002. The upgrade was documented in the Plateau State Legal Notice No. 92 Gazette Vol. II dated 12th October, 2006. Later on, in the year 2018, the stool of Ujah Anaguta was further upgraded to First Class status by the then Executive Governor of Plateau State, Rt. Hon. Barr. Simon Bako Lalong, with effect from 14th August, 2018.

The current Ujah Anaguta Jos, His Royal Majesty, **Pozoh Johnson Jauro Magaji II**, President Jos North Traditional Council is the ninth in succession. He was coronated on 17th June, 2021.